Gustavo Acosta

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GitHub

Fields of Interest

Development Economics, Global Health Economics, Labor Economics

Education

University of Michigan

Ph.D. Candidate in Economics — *2023–Present*

University of Michigan

M.A. in Economics (Pathway to Ph.D.) — *2025*

Pontifical Catholic University of Peru (PUCP)

B.Sc. in Economics — *2013–2018*

Research Experience

University of Michigan

Research Associate — *2024–2025*

- PI: Emma Riley. Project on adolescent girls' economic and social empowerment in Tanzania (2025).
- PI: Elisa Maffioli. Projects on malaria vaccines and fake drugs in Africa (2024–2025).

Duke University

Pre-Doctoral Research Fellow — *2020–2023*

- PIs: Erica Field, Robert Garlick, and Katherine Vyborny. Projects in Peru and Pakistan on health, gender, labor markets, and survey methodology.

Innovations for Poverty Action

Senior Research Associate — *2018–2020*

- Peru. PIs: Erica Field, Livia Schubiger, and Javier Romero. Projects on health and gender-based violence.
- Paraguay. PI: Nathan Fiala. Projects on poverty and financial inclusion.

Working Papers

Are Insiders or Community Leaders Effective in Identifying Intimate Partner Violence? With Erica Field. Draft available upon request.

Text Messaging for Mental Health Management During the COVID-19 Pandemic. With Erica Field, Daniel Hurtado, and Javier Romero. Draft available upon request.

Imprecise Beliefs About Malaria Infection Risk and Vaccine Protection in Ghana (Third-Year Paper). Draft available upon request.

Higher Education Reforms and Political Outcomes. With Leah Lakdawala and Fabiola Alba. Draft available upon request.

Work in Progress

Enhancing Women's Safety in Public Spaces: Training Community Volunteers to Reduce Gender-Based Violence in Peru. With Marcia Ruiz and Guiliana Campos. Pilot completed, with data collection scheduled for 2026.

Sustaining Public Infrastructure: A Gender-Informed Behavioral Intervention for Housing Maintenance in Peru. With Marcia Ruiz and Emily Saavedra. Baseline completed, with data collection scheduled for 2026.

Targeting Men to Reduce Domestic Violence: An Evaluation of Men for Equality. With Erica Field. Baseline completed, with endline data collection scheduled for 2026.

Sustaining Shared Urban Sanitation in Uganda. With Marcia Ruiz and Laston Manja. Pilot completed, with data collection scheduled for 2026.

The Price of Safety: The Effects of Extortion on Small-Scale Entrepreneurship in Peru. With Gabby Lecaro. Data collection scheduled for 2026.

Formal Savings Adoption Among Vulnerable Populations in Colombia: Evidence from a Banca de las Oportunidades Intervention. With Tommaso Crosta. Implementation funding secured, with fieldwork preparation underway for 2026.

Providing Real-Time, Accurate Data to Increase Malaria Vaccine Completion Rates in Ghana. With Jessica Cohen and Elisa Maffioli. Baseline completed.

Mitigating the Impact of Health and Climate Shocks on School Performance in Malawi: The Role of School Management Structures. With Laston Manja.

Evaluating OCP Nigeria's Farm & Fortune Hubs and OCP School Lab. With Nilesh Fernando. Design stage.

School Feeding and Human Capital Development in Peru. With Muchin Bazan and Shahadath Hossain.

Pre-Doctoral Publications

Acosta, G. and P. Francke. 2021. "Impact of the Qali Warma School Feeding Program on Chronic Child Malnutrition." *Apuntes*.

Acosta, G. and P. Francke. 2020. "Impact of Micronutrients 'Sprinkles' on Chronic Childhood Malnutrition in Peru." *Revista Médica Herediana*.

Policy Notes

Acosta, G., E. Field, H. Khan, and K. Vyborny. 2023. *Lockdowns and Learning Outcomes: Insights from 10th Grade Examination Results in Pakistan*. C-19 Notes, PEDL.

Awards, Fellowships, and Grants

Peruvian Government Funding through IPA Peru, *Targeting Men to Reduce Domestic Violence: An Evaluation of Men for Equality*. Co-PI with Erica Field — USD $90,000 (2026).

Marshall Weinberg Population, Development and Climate Change Fellowship, Institute for Social Research, University of Michigan, *Sustaining Shared Urban Sanitation in Uganda*. Lead-PI with Marcia Ruiz and Laston Manja — USD $8,500 (2026).

J-PAL Crime and Violence Initiative (CVI), Pre-Approval, *Sexual Harassment in Peru*. Lead-PI with Marcia Ruiz — USD $50,000 (2026).

Sexual Violence Research Initiative (SVRI), *Sexual Harassment in Peru*. Lead-PI with Marcia Ruiz and Pedro Francke — USD $100,000 (2026).

The Weiss Fund, *Sexual Harassment in Peru*. — USD $25,000 (2025).

University of Michigan PACLSHR, *Sexual Harassment in Peru.* — USD $6,000 (2025).
Rackham Graduate Student Research Grant, *Sexual Harassment in Peru.* — USD $1,500 (2025).
Rackham Graduate Student Research Grant, *Extortion in Peru.* Co-PI with Gabby Lecaro — USD $1,500 (2025).
Sylff Research Grant, *Sustaining Public Infrastructure in Peru.* Lead-PI with Marcia Ruiz — USD $10,000 (2025).
Rackham Graduate Student Research Grant, *Sustaining Public Infrastructure in Peru.* Co-PI with Marcia Ruiz — USD $1,500 (2025).
Marshall Weinberg Population, Development and Climate Change Fellowship, Institute for Social Research, University of Michigan, *Sustaining Public Infrastructure in Peru.* Lead-PI with Marcia Ruiz — USD $8,500 (2025).
International Growth Centre (IGC) Grant, *Sustaining Shared Urban Sanitation in Uganda.* Lead-PI with Marcia Ruiz and Laston Manja — USD $28,500 (2025).
The Weiss Fund, *Ghana Malaria Vaccine Adherence RCT.* Co-Investigator, with Jessica Cohen and Elisa Maffioli. USD $199,000 (2025).
Global Development Incubator, *Ghana Malaria Vaccine Adherence RCT.* Co-Investigator, with Jessica Cohen and Elisa Maffioli. USD $1,220,000 (2025).
Economic and Social Research Consortium (CIES/USAID), *Peruvian Public Health System: A Machine Learning Approach.* With Pedro Francke — USD $5,000 (2020).
National Institute of Statistics and Information (INEI), *The Effects of Social Programs on Malnutrition* — USD $7,000 (2019).
Superintendence of Banks, Insurance and PFAs, Scholarship for Advanced Economics Program (2018).
PUCP Economics Department, First Place in Research Paper Thesis Competition (2018).
International Student Exchange Program Scholarship, Australian National University — AUD $5,000 (2017).

Seminars and Conferences

RIDGE Summer School, Barbados. May 2026.
Arnold Ventures BRIDGE Event on Online Harassment and Stalking, Washington, DC. April 2026.
Midwest Economics Association Conference, Chicago, IL (participant). March 2026.
University of Ghana School of Public Health Seminar, Accra, Ghana. "Imprecise Beliefs About Malaria Infection Risk and Vaccine Protection in Ghana." October 2025.
Empirical Study of Gender (EGEN) Pakistan Workshop II, CERP, Lahore, Pakistan. "Impact of the COVID-19 Pandemic on Labor Markets in Pakistan." March 2022.
DevLab Seminar, Duke University, Durham, NC. "Impact of the COVID-19 Pandemic on Labor Markets in Pakistan." November 2021.
CIES Annual Research Seminar, Lima, Peru. With Pedro Francke and Diego Quispe. "At the Other Extreme: Does the Qali Warma Program Increase the Incidence of Overweight and Obesity Among Boys and Girls Ages 3 to 5?" November 2020.
Presentation of Pilot Results from a Group-Based Intervention to Peru's Minister of Women, Lima, Peru. February 2020.

Current Collaborations

Ministry of Women and Vulnerable Populations, Peru, 2018–Present
Ministry of Housing, Construction, and Sanitation, Peru, 2024–Present
Ghana Health Services, Ghana, 2025–Present
Ministry of Lands, Housing and Urban Development, Uganda, 2025–Present
Ministry of Health, Uganda, 2026–Present
Kampala Capital City Authority, Uganda, 2025–Present
Banca de las Oportunidades, Colombia, 2026–Present

Teaching Experience

University of Michigan
Teaching Assistant, Economics 101 — *2024–2026*
Pontifical Catholic University of Peru
Adjunct Professor, Thesis Seminar I — *2026*
Pontifical Catholic University of Peru
Teaching Assistant, Macroeconomics — *2018*

Skills

Software: Stata, R, Julia, Python, Matlab, SurveyCTO, Qualtrics, LaTeX
Languages: Spanish (native), English (professional proficiency), Chinese (basic proficiency)